was the plan. Today, after Rs 17 crore spent, it has only yielded a trail of questions, controversies and disturbing animal mortality rates.

NO HOLY COWS

Here's how the milk boiled over. After a year, project control was ceded to an 11-member 'society' headed by Sootea MLA Padma Hazarika. Its roster boasted big BJP names like MP and state party chief Dilip Saikia, besides top bureaucrats. The procurement unfolded in three phases. Two were kosher: 98 cows, for Rs 82 lakh, in 2021; then 24 cows and a bullock, with World Bank funds, in January 2022. The third phase saw the twist.

In April 2022, the National Dairy Development Board (NDDB) was to deliver 300 Gir cows. In



OUT TO PASTURE Insets: State BJP chief Saikia (left), MLA Hazarika; below: cows at Gorukhuti Bahumukhi Krishi Prakalpa



March 2023, state agriculture minister Atul Bora told the assembly all 300 were returned, the funds remaining unspent. But official records show he misled the House: 210 cows had indeed reached the site, with NDDB getting paid. Later, 154 cows were returned because of poor quality, while 56 died.

The remaining 90 took a different path. An RTI reply showed that, on Hazarika's advice, these were to be distributed among farmers by seven "public representatives"—the list reads like a who's who of Assam politics. BJP honcho Saikia took two. Three MLAs accounted for 16: Bhuban Pegu (10), Utpal Borah (4), Diganta Kalita (2). The lion's share went to two individuals with no official position, and one private firm. Babul Nath and Neeraj Bora, said to be close to Hazarika, got 30 and 20 respectively. JMB Aqua Agro, a dairy firm owned by Julee D. Baruah, wife of minister Jayanta Malla Baruah, got 20. No public ads, no selection criteria to explain the choices.

Takeaways

- **Project intended to power Assam's dairy sector runs into a storm of questions**
- **Agriculture minister says in the assembly that cows were returned, no money spent. Records prove otherwise**
- **State BJP chief, minister and MLAs 'privatise' Gir cows imported from Gujarat for the dairy project**

Worse, the 90 prize cows were never distributed. They simply went into private hands. Hazarika first said the seven had "bought" the cows, paying NDDB directly. But the paper trail belied that. Nath and Bora had paid NDDB directly. But it was GBKP that paid Rs 13.2 lakh for 20 "pregnant" cows taken by five beneficiaries, who had made payments at the deputy commissioner's office in Darrang. Saikia, instead of paying the full amount, offered himself a bite-sized discount of Rs 32,000. Scanty? Not so for the Opposition, which is whipping up good cream from the spilt milk. ■



By **Kavitha Muralidharan**

TAMIL NADU'S MODEL of good governance has some unwashed stains around its edges—and they go from deep, clotted red to fresh crimson every now and then, with a new case of police violence. That dark calendar returned to the spotlight in late June, with the custodial death of Ajith Kumar, a 27-year-old temple security guard, in Sivaganga district. In the ensuing storm, what came in for scrutiny is a deeply endemic crisis: a political culture that's tolerant of the law behaving lawlessly, regardless of who runs the government.

This is not the first time the ruling DMK is being called out for fostering a climate of police impunity—the 2023 custodial torture case of Ambasamudram was still fresh in the mind. This time, though, the DMK government moved with relative swiftness: five policemen were arrested, six suspended; a CBI probe was ordered; and an apol-